

Call him the keeper of traditional Indian wisdom. Or a generator of latent rural Indian energy. Call him whatever you want, but something that can't be denied is his place in Indian history as the pilot of the largest-ever knowledge bank made by little-known pioneers living in uncelebrated Indian towns and no-name

villages. Anil Kumar Gupta, a professor at the Centre for Management in Agriculture at IIM-Ahmedabad (IIM-A), is more famous now as the vice chairman of National Innovation Foundation (NIF), a central government-funded body that he helped form in 2000 and that now presides over a database of traditional knowledge comprising 75,000 innova-

tions and practices from across the country. The database touches almost every sphere from transport, energy and food technology to agriculture and livestock.

Some of the discoveries identified by Society for Research and Initiatives in Sustainable Technologies and Institutions (SRISTI), an Ahmedabad-based NGO four-



thinking LOCAL

✱ **Anil K. Gupta, 58**

Project Unleashing the innovative spirit in rural India

Can-do Icon Mahatma Gandhi, because he had faith in the inherent talent hidden in the villages and small towns of India, talent that has the potential to help all of mankind

15,262 patents were granted in India in 2007-08, while 1,57,284 patents were granted by the US patent office



Photographs by SHAILESH RAVAL